

Organic Crown Prince Squash Information Pack

Introduction

Crown Prince is a variety of squash that was bred specifically to suit the climate in the UK. The name comes from its bold, regal blue colour and a rich tradition of naming crop cultivars after members of the royal family to connote dependability (king Edward potatoes, Prince of Wales apples). The edible skin and high sugar content makes it most suitable to roasting, as it caramelises easily to form a delicious crust.

Farm Information

Our Organic Crown Prince Squash this week is grown on Foskett's Farm in Suffolk. James Foskett is the second generation of the family to farm here and moved much of the land into organic production when he took over. They have nailed the tricky business of managing pest pressure and soil fertility without synthetic chemicals at scale and now produce crops of an incredibly high quality and consistency including carrots, cavolo, sweetcorn and beetroot.

Like butternut, Crown prince squash are a key part of the crop rotation that is employed on organic farms to maintain soil fertility. They were traditionally grown as part of the 'Three Sisters' growing methodology pioneered by the indigenous population of north and central America and are still used for this purpose today. Each different plant type extracts a slightly different selection of nutrients from the soil, so if you continuously plant the same crop in the same field you will find yourself deficient in those nutrients, so you must switch it up with a crop rotation.

Similarly, pests tend to be plant specific, so breaking the cycle with a totally different kind of plant will keep the pests 'on their toes' as it were. Finally, squash grow on a sprawling ground level vine with huge leaves which dominate the surface and reduce the amount of light available to weeds, whilst ensuring the soil is covered and protected from erosion. Due to their low water content squash can be stored for months on end without going bad and so also represents a great commercial opportunity for farmers to diversify their income into the winter months when many other crops are out of season.

Nutritionally crown prince squash is rich in beta-carotene (a precursor to vitamin A), which supports eye and immune health, and it provides a good amount of vitamin C, potassium, and fibre. Squash also contains antioxidants that help reduce inflammation, and its complex carbohydrates offer slow, steady energy. Being organic, this product is devoid of agrochemical residue.

See our Instagram account for more squash-based content